The Unconveyable Situation:
Obstructed Conveyance, Second-Order Silence, and a Single-Root Account of Autistic Masking

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Abstract

The paper proposes a root for autistic masking: a pervasive inability to convey the truth of one's situation to others, which closes on itself. The account starts from a dated case. An autistic adult telling a short story to his father is interrupted about six times in two minutes by a visitor to the house, who then, with a hand on his shoulder and the words "I don't want to interrupt but," sends him to help his sister with a task. The case is read as an instance of a structure with three parts: a first-order obstruction, in which holding the conversational floor long enough to complete a thought requires either resisting interruptions at a social cost or yielding and losing the thought; a second-order obstruction, in which the report of the first is a longer turn than the one it reports and is heard through a frame that discounts it; and an attribution, in which the silence the two produce is read as a deficit of the person, which strengthens the frame. A model with a Poisson interruption process shows that the probability of completing a turn decays exponentially in the number of interlocutors; that no mixed policy of resisting and yielding beats the pure ones, and both lose to silence beyond a threshold that falls with the length of the thought; that the report of the obstruction is at most as conveyable as what it reports; and that the attribution loop has silence as an absorbing state that no move of the person's escapes, at which a definite part of the person's situation is inaccessible and the part is closed under description, so that its own edge cannot be told. Masking is derived

1 Introduction

1.1 A case

On the morning of November 6, 2026, the author was telling his father a story, the one in which Russell, in the autumn of 1911, could not get the young Wittgenstein to admit that it was certain there was no rhinoceros in the room [3]. A visitor to the house interrupted him about six times in two minutes. At the end she touched him on the shoulder and said, "I don't want to interrupt but why don't you go help your sister download an app she's looking for." The story was not finished. His note of 10:30 AM, written within the hour and quoted whole in Appendix A, reads

*Email: akb9408@rit.edu, Website: `https://aethus.org`. The author wrote the note on which this paper rests on November 6, 2026 (Appendix A), and had Claude Fable 5.1 convert it into the paper at his direction the same day; the division between what is his and what is the conversion's is stated there. The paper is self-contained; its one companion in the psychology of interaction is a cost model of interaction under governing norms [1], drawn from the same larger framework [2], whose metaphysics plays no role here.

the episode as the most concise root explanation of autistic masking he has managed to write, and the present paper is that note carried out.

The reading has four parts, each visible in the case. First, what the visitor did was not to forbid the story but to keep constant pressure on him to mask, so that conveying the thought required consciously resisting, interruption by interruption. Second, a room full of allistic people scales the same pressure by the number of people in it, at which point the thought is not resisted for but given up: one learns to stay quiet. Third, the giving-up has a shape. Thinking of a funny story comes to translate, by a route the person can watch operate, into the conclusion that one had better keep one's mouth shut, so the isolation is produced inside the person by the room's pressure and then felt as one's own. Fourth, the result is read from outside as a deficit. The person is criticized for not making friends, as if the silence were a problem with him in particular, and the criticism cannot be answered, because answering it would require conveying the dynamic just described, which is a longer and less credible turn than the story that could not be finished. The note's word for this last part is Cassandra, and its closing sentence is that, as an autistic person, he does not have a voice in this world.

1.2 The claim

The note's claim is stronger than the case. It is that the root of autistic masking is the pervasive inability to convey the truth of one's situation to others, that this inability spirals into a self-reinforcing isolation, and that all autistic masking effects, and their contribution to autistic burnout, are outputs or shadows of this single abstraction. The paper states the abstraction, builds a model in which the case's four parts are theorems rather than descriptions, derives masking and its load from the model, states the single-root hypothesis with what would refute it, places the account in the literature, and gives predictions that separate it from its neighbors.

Two things are fixed before the argument begins. The vocabulary of the claim is interactional throughout: the quantities are rates of interruption, lengths of turns, costs of resisting, and the frame through which a room hears an account, and no quantity measures a person's capacity. And the claim is scoped to masking and to masking's contribution to burnout. Burnout has other contributors, sensory load and life stressors among them [4, 5], and the hypothesis says nothing about those.

1.3 Plan

Section 2 reads the case slowly. Section 3 states the abstraction and names its three parts. Section 4 builds the model and proves four propositions. Section 5 derives masking, its load and burnout. Section 6 runs the orders upward and takes apart the reply the account most often receives. Section 7 states the single-root hypothesis.

2 The case, read slowly

Four features of the episode carry the argument, and each is a feature of the interaction and not of anyone's intention.

The obstruction is additive and unintended. Six interruptions in two minutes is a rate, and a rate is the right description, because no single interruption did the work. Each was, taken alone, ordinary: a question, an aside, a suggestion. The story was lost to their accumulation.

This is why the note moves at once from the one visitor to the room full of people: several people, each interrupting at an ordinary rate and none intending to silence anyone, produce between them a rate at which no story survives. The obstruction is a property of the sum.

The double bind. At each interruption the speaker has two moves. He can hold the floor, which reads as inconsiderate, since the interruption was itself a bid for the floor and refusing it is a refusal of the other person; or he can yield, which loses the thought, since a story cut six times is not a story. The note's phrase is that he has to consciously resist in order to convey his thought. Both moves cost; the only move that costs nothing in the moment is not to have started. That is the shape of the whole account, and Section 4 shows it is forced: no mixture of resisting and yielding does better than the two pure policies, and both lose to silence once the rate is high enough.

The floor was never his. The visitor's last utterance acknowledges the norm against interrupting and overrides it in the same breath, and it redirects him from a contribution of his own to an instrumental task on someone else's behalf. The utterance establishes nothing about her intentions; she may have thought the task urgent, or not have noticed the count. What it establishes is that his turn was not, in that room, a turn with the standing of other people's: no one protected it, and when it was taken no one returned it. In the vocabulary of conversation analysis, where the floor is allocated by a turn-taking system that treats a current speaker's turn as a resource to be relinquished at a transition point and not before [6], his turn had no transition points; it was open at every moment.

The report is harder than the story. The feature that makes the case more than a complaint is the last. If asked afterward why he is quiet in company, the true answer is the dynamic above, and the dynamic is a longer turn than the rhinoceros story, told to listeners who already hold a frame on which quietness is a trait of his. The report of the obstruction is subject to the obstruction, at greater length and lower credibility. This is what the note calls the Cassandra-like inability to convey even a fragment of the real dynamic. Cassandra's curse in the *Agamemnon* is not silence; she speaks, and truly, and is not believed [7]. The case's version is exact: the one thing that would explain the silence is the thing the silence prevents from being said.

3 The abstraction

The four features assemble into one structure, and the paper's claim is that the structure, and not any of its features, is the root.

Definition 1 (Conveyance; the two orders)**.** A *thought* is a unit of content whose transmission requires an uninterrupted stretch of the conversational floor of some length. A thought is *conveyed* when that stretch is completed and the content received. A *first-order* thought is any content the person wants to transmit. The *second-order* thought attached to a failed first-order attempt is the account of why it failed: the obstruction, described.

Definition 2 (The unconveyable situation)**.** A person is in an *unconveyable situation* with respect to a room when three conditions hold.

(i) *First-order obstruction.* The room's interruption rate on the person's turns is high enough that completing a first-order thought requires either resisting interruptions at a social cost or yielding and losing the thought.

(ii) *Second-order obstruction.* The second-order thought is at least as long as the first-order thoughts it reports, and the room hears it through a frame on which the person's silence is a trait of the person, so that the account is discounted.

(iii) *Attribution.* The silence produced by (i) and (ii) is read by the room as evidence for the frame in (ii).

The three conditions are not independent symptoms; (iii) feeds (ii), and (ii) removes the only route by which the person could change (i). That is what makes the structure a root and not a list. The note's word for the whole is the pervasive inability to convey the truth of one's situation, where *situation* is doing the work: what cannot be conveyed is not the story but the fact that stories cannot be conveyed.

Two literatures have names for parts of the structure, and the names are used below. Fricker distinguishes testimonial injustice, in which a speaker's word is given less credibility than it deserves because of a prejudice about the kind of speaker she is, from hermeneutical injustice, in which a gap in the shared interpretive resources leaves a person unable to make her experience intelligible to others [8]. Condition (ii) contains both: the discount is testimonial, and the absence, in the room's repertoire, of any concept on which silence is produced by the room is hermeneutical. Catala, Faucher and Poirier argue that autistic people's epistemic agency is relational, constituted in part by the social environment, and that features of the environment can disable it; they locate the disabling in neuronormativity and in neurotypical ignorance about autistic sociability [9]. Definition 2 is a mechanism of epistemic disablement in their sense, written at the grain of the floor.

4 A model

4.1 The floor and the interruption process

An *episode* is an attempt to convey a thought that requires uninterrupted floor time $\tau > 0$. Interruptions on the speaker's turns arrive as a Poisson process of rate $\lambda > 0$; with n interlocutors who interrupt independently at rates $\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_n$, $\lambda = \sum_i \lambda_i$, and in the symmetric case $\lambda = n\lambda_1$. At each interruption the speaker either *resists*, keeping the floor at a cost $r > 0$, the cost of reading as inconsiderate, or *yields*, losing the floor and the thought. A *policy* is a probability $\rho \in [0, 1]$ of resisting each interruption, independently. Attempting costs $c_0 > 0$ whether or not it succeeds, the effort of formulation and the exposure of a thought cut off; conveying the thought is worth $V > c_0$. Silence costs nothing in the episode and conveys nothing. The rate λ is a property of the room's treatment of this speaker's turns, and the model's one empirical premise is about it.

Premise 1 (Floor asymmetry)**.** In an allistic-majority room, an autistic speaker's extended turns face a higher interruption rate than an allistic speaker's turns of the same length.

The premise is the case's third feature stated as a rate, and it is where the evidence enters; Section 8 collects what bears on it and Section 9 tests it directly. Nothing in the propositions depends on why the rate is higher.

4.2 The first order: the completion law and the double bind

Proposition 1 (The completion law and the double bind)**.** *Let $U(\rho)$ be the expected value of an attempt under policy ρ, relative to silence.*

(a) The thought is conveyed with probability $P(\rho) = \exp\{-\lambda\tau(1-\rho)\}$, and $U(\rho) = Ve^{-\lambda\tau(1-\rho)} - r\rho\lambda\tau - c_0$. At fixed policy, completion decays exponentially in $\lambda\tau$, and so in the number of interlocutors.

(b) U is strictly convex in ρ, so the best policy is pure: always yield, worth $U(0) = Ve^{-\lambda\tau} - c_0$, or always resist, worth $U(1) = V - r\lambda\tau - c_0$.

(c) Both pure values fall in $\lambda\tau$, the first exponentially and the second linearly, and the person attempts at all exactly when

$$\lambda\tau \;<\; \theta^* \;:=\; \max\Big\{\ln\frac{V}{c_0},\ \frac{V-c_0}{r}\Big\}.$$

With $\lambda = n\lambda_1$ this is $n < n^* := \theta^*/(\lambda_1\tau)$: the room has a size beyond which the thought is not attempted, and the size falls as the thought lengthens.

Proof. (a) The number of interruptions in $[0,\tau]$ is Poisson with mean $\lambda\tau$, the thought completes when every one is resisted, and $\mathbb{E}[\rho^N] = e^{-\lambda\tau(1-\rho)}$; the expected number resisted is $\rho\lambda\tau$, each at cost r. (b) $U''(\rho) = V(\lambda\tau)^2 e^{-\lambda\tau(1-\rho)} > 0$, and a strictly convex function on an interval is maximized at an endpoint. (c) $U(0) > 0$ iff $\lambda\tau < \ln(V/c_0)$ and $U(1) > 0$ iff $\lambda\tau < (V-c_0)/r$; the person attempts when either holds. □

The proposition is the case's first two features as theorems. The exponential in (a) is the note's scaling of the dynamic by the number of people: with the same policy, each added interlocutor multiplies the completion probability by the same factor $e^{-\lambda_1\tau}$. The convexity in (b) is the double bind: there is no policy of partial resistance that does better than the two stark ones, so the speaker really faces the choice the note describes, to resist and be read as inconsiderate or to yield and lose the thought. And (c) is the giving-up, with its two features that matter later. Silence is reached at a finite room size, and the size is smaller for longer thoughts: remarks survive rooms in which stories do not, and explanations, which are longer than stories, are the first to go.

4.3 The second order: the Cassandra inequality

Let the second-order thought, the account of the obstruction, require floor time τ_2, and let the room hold the frame on which the person's silence is a trait of the person with probability $\pi \in [0,1]$. Under the frame the account, if completed, is accepted with probability $\kappa \in [0,1)$, the account reading as excuse; outside the frame a completed account is accepted.

Proposition 2 (The Cassandra inequality)**.** *Under any policy ρ, the account of the obstruction is accepted with probability*

$$P_2(\rho) \;=\; e^{-\lambda\tau_2(1-\rho)}\big(1-\pi(1-\kappa)\big),$$

and if $\tau_2 \geq \tau$ then $P_2(\rho) \leq P(\rho)$, with strict inequality whenever $\pi > 0$, or $\tau_2 > \tau$ and $\rho < 1$. The report of the obstruction is at most as conveyable as what the obstruction blocked.

Proof. The account is a turn and completes by the law of Proposition 1(a) with τ_2 in place of τ; acceptance given completion is $(1-\pi)+\pi\kappa$. Both factors are at most the corresponding factors of $P(\rho)$, the second being at most 1. □

The inequality is the case's fourth feature, and it is the hinge of the account, because the second-order thought is the only move by which the person could change λ: a listener who accepts that the silence is produced by the room can protect the floor. Proposition 2 says that this move is never more available than the first-order thought whose failure it would explain. Where stories fail, explanations of why stories fail do worse.

4.4 The loop: silence is absorbing

Rounds $t = 1, 2, \ldots$ are episodes in one room. The room's frame weight π_t sets the interruption rate through a nondecreasing function, $\lambda_t = \lambda(\pi_t)$: a room that holds the person's silence to be a trait of the person protects his turns less. In round t the person attempts exactly when $\lambda_t\tau < \theta^*$, by Proposition 1(c). The room updates on what it observes: a round without a completed conveyance, whether silence or an attempt cut off, raises the frame weight, $\pi_{t+1} = \pi_t + \alpha(1-\pi_t)$ with $\alpha \in (0,1]$, since what the room sees is a person who did not say anything and the correspondence bias reads an outcome as a disposition [10]; a round with a completed conveyance lowers it, $\pi_{t+1} = (1-\beta)\pi_t$ with $\beta \in [0,1]$.

Proposition 3 (Absorbing silence)**.** *If $\lambda(\pi_t)\tau \geq \theta^*$ at some round t, then the person is silent at every round from t on and $\pi_t \to 1$. Within the loop, the silent state is left only by an exogenous change: a fall in $\lambda(\cdot)$ not produced by the person's conveyance, or a fall in π not produced by it.*

Proof. At round t the person is silent, so no conveyance completes and $\pi_{t+1} \geq \pi_t$; λ is nondecreasing in π, so $\lambda_{t+1}\tau \geq \lambda_t\tau \geq \theta^*$ and the person is silent at $t+1$. By induction the person is silent at every later round, and $1-\pi_{t+k} = (1-\alpha)^k(1-\pi_t) \to 0$. The person's only instruments are conveyances, first- or second-order, and none occurs in the silent state, so any exit is produced by something other than the person. □

The proposition is the note's spiral. Once the room's rate crosses the threshold, every later round confirms the frame, the frame raises the rate, and nothing the person does from inside reverses it, because every reversal would be a conveyance and conveyances are what the state excludes. Two further things follow and are worth saying plainly. Before the threshold, every attempt that is cut off also raises π, so the approach to the threshold is itself accelerated by trying; a person who keeps attempting in a room near the threshold moves the room toward it. And the exits named in the proposition are the room's: a change in its composition, or a member who arrives already holding the situational frame, from some source other than the person's testimony.

4.5 The fixed point: the inaccessible region, and the ghost

The loop has been followed for one thought. A person's situation is many, and following the loop over all of them gives the fixed point its content: not that one story goes untold, but that a definite part of the person becomes unreachable from inside, and that the part includes its own boundary.

Let the person's *situation* be a finite set S of thoughts, each $s \in S$ with a floor time $\tau(s) > 0$, a value $V(s) > c_0$, and a weight $m(s) > 0$ measuring how much its conveyance matters; write $m(A) = \sum_{s \in A} m(s)$. In a room of rate λ the *conveyable region* is

$$C(\lambda) \;=\; \{\, s \in S : \lambda\,\tau(s) < \theta^*(s) \,\}, \qquad \theta^*(s) = \max\Big\{ \ln \frac{V(s)}{c_0},\; \frac{V(s) - c_0}{r} \Big\},$$

the thoughts the person attempts there by Proposition 1(c); the *inaccessible region* is $I(\lambda) = S \setminus C(\lambda)$ and the *inaccessible fraction* is $f(\lambda) = m(I(\lambda))/m(S)$. For $s \in I(\lambda)$ let s' be its *report*: the second-order thought that s cannot be told in this room, and why. Two things are assumed of reports. A report is at least as long as what it reports, $\tau(s') \geq \tau(s)$, since it must carry the thought's size together with the dynamic; and a report is credited at no more than the thought's own value, $(1 - \pi(1-\kappa))\, V(s') \leq V(s)$, the acceptance factor of Proposition 2 applying to accounts, which at the fixed point $\pi = 1$ reads $\kappa V(s') \leq V(s)$.

Proposition 4 (The inaccessible region)**.** *(a) $C(\lambda)$ is nonincreasing in λ and $f(\lambda)$ nondecreasing: as the loop raises the room's rate, the conveyable region shrinks, and at the loop's stationary rate λ^* the inaccessible fraction is $f(\lambda^*)$, which is the greater the more of the situation's weight lies in long thoughts.*

(b) The cutoff rises only logarithmically in value: for the thoughts the person attempts, the admissible length $\theta^*(s)/\lambda$ grows as $\ln V(s)$ while the resisting branch is inactive, so a thought that matters a hundred times more earns a few times the floor.

(c) $I(\lambda)$ is closed under reporting: if $s \in I(\lambda)$ then $s' \in I(\lambda)$. In particular the boundary of $C(\lambda)$, which thoughts can and cannot be told in this room, is itself untellable in it.

Proof. (a) The condition $\lambda\tau(s) < \theta^*(s)$ is monotone in λ for each s. (b) $\theta^*(s) = \ln(V(s)/c_0)$ on the branch where the logarithm is the larger term. (c) Let $s \in I(\lambda)$, so $\lambda\tau(s) \geq \theta^*(s)$. The report is an account, credited at $(1 - \pi(1-\kappa))V(s')$, so it is attempted exactly when $\lambda\tau(s') < \theta^*$ evaluated at that value; since θ^* is increasing in its value and the value is at most $V(s)$, that threshold is at most $\theta^*(s)$, while $\lambda\tau(s') \geq \lambda\tau(s) \geq \theta^*(s)$. The statement about the boundary is the case in which s is any thought on it. □

Part (c) is the sense in which the inaccessibility is topological rather than probabilistic, and the note's word is the right one. It is not that long thoughts are unlikely to get through; a probability can be raised by trying. It is that the inaccessible region is closed under the one operation, description, that could bring any of its members within reach: the description of an unreachable thought is unreachable, and so is the description of the line between the reachable and the unreachable. A person at the fixed point therefore cannot convey the size of what they cannot convey. From outside, the region does not exist; from inside, its edge cannot be pointed at. Part (b) adds that mattering does not help: the thoughts that carry the situation's weight are its long ones, the structure of a life rather than its incidents, and the floor a thought earns grows with the logarithm of what it is worth.

The ghost. What a room holds of a person is what has been conveyed, together with the frame. At the fixed point the room's record of the person is $C(\lambda^*)$ filled out by π: the short thoughts, and the attribution that explains the absence of the rest. Call $1 - f(\lambda^*) = m(C(\lambda^*))/m(S)$ the person's *presence* in the room, the fraction of the person that the room's record contains. When

the inaccessible fraction is major, the person present in the room, as the room has them, is mostly not the person, and the person can see this and cannot amend it, since every amendment is a report and reports are in I. The relation that remains to the room is observation: the person watches the room's version of themselves as a third party would, and watches the room from a position no move of theirs can alter. This is the note's ghost, present in the room and absent from its record, viewing the outside world in the third person, and the model predicts the phenomenology without adding a mechanism for it: a participant is one whose moves change the room's record, and a person none of whose moves can is, in the only sense the room affords, not there. The camouflaging literature records challenges to identity and the sense of not being one's own self among masking's costs [11, 12]; the presence quotient locates the cost in the record and not in the person, and predicts it to track the inaccessible fraction, which is the test given as P8 below.

5 Masking, its load, and burnout

5.1 Masking as the middle regime

The model so far has two options, speech and silence. Masking is a third, and it is defined here by what it does to the exposure. A *masked attempt* is one reshaped in advance to lower the room's interruption rate on it: the thought shortened, pre-edited, delivered in the room's register, its objections pre-empted. The forms are those the camouflaging literature catalogues under compensation, masking and assimilation [11, 13, 14], and the model abstracts from the forms to their effect. A masked attempt faces rate $\mu\lambda$ with $\mu \in (0, 1)$ and pays an additional cost $c_M > 0$, the effort of the reshaping, on top of c_0. The person now chooses among silence, an unmasked attempt and a masked one; the statement is given for yielding policies, where the structure is cleanest, and write $x = \lambda\tau$ for the exposure.

Proposition 5 (The forced-masking band)**.** *Under yielding policies, the unmasked attempt beats silence exactly when $x < x_u := \ln(V/c_0)$, and the masked attempt beats silence exactly when $x < x_M := \mu^{-1} \ln\big(V/(c_0 + c_M)\big)$.*

(a) $x_M > x_u$ exactly when $c_M < V^{1-\mu} c_0^{\mu} - c_0$, a bound that is positive since $\mu < 1$ and $c_0 < V$: for a mask cheap enough relative to what it saves, there is a band of exposures $x_u \le x < x_M$ on which the thought is said masked or not at all.

(b) Below x_u the person may still mask, and does so exactly when $V(e^{-\mu x} - e^{-x}) > c_M$, the mask's gain in completion exceeding its cost.

(c) The person is silent exactly when $x \ge \max\{x_u, x_M\}$; when the band exists, this is $x \ge x_M$.

Proof. The unmasked yielding value is $Ve^{-x} - c_0$ and the masked one $Ve^{-\mu x} - c_0 - c_M$; each is positive on the stated interval. For (a), $x_M > x_u$ iff $\ln(V/(c_0 + c_M)) > \mu \ln(V/c_0)$ iff $c_0 + c_M < V^{1-\mu} c_0^{\mu}$, and $V^{1-\mu} c_0^{\mu} > c_0$ because $V > c_0$ and $1 - \mu > 0$. (b) is the difference of the two values. (c) Silence beats both attempts exactly when neither value is positive. □

The band in (a) is the proposition's content. In a room whose exposure lies in it, the unmasked thought is not worth attempting, the masked one is, and the person who speaks at all speaks masked. The band widens as the mask becomes more effective (μ falls) and narrows as it becomes more costly (c_M rises), and its position in the number of interlocutors is $n_u \le n < n_M$

with $n_u = x_u/(\lambda_1\tau)$ and $n_M = x_M/(\lambda_1\tau)$. The three regimes are therefore ordered in the room's size: speech, masked where the mask pays and unmasked where it does not, in small rooms; forced masking in middling ones; silence in large ones; with the boundaries moving inward as the thought lengthens. This is the note's observation that the pressure to mask is the room's and is constant: at every exposure in the band, the choice between masking and silence is renewed at each episode, and the person who wants to be heard pays c_M each time.

5.2 Load and burnout

Let the person pass through episodes $t = 1, \ldots, T$ in rooms of exposures x_t, and let the *masking load* be $L_T = \sum_{t \le T} c_M \, \mathbf{1}[\text{episode } t \text{ masked}]$. Autistic burnout, as defined from lived experience, is a state of chronic exhaustion, loss of skills and reduced tolerance to stimulus, produced when expectations outweigh abilities under cumulative load without adequate supports [4], with exhaustion, withdrawal and executive difficulty as its core features [15]; masking is the contributor most often named in first-person accounts [16], and the conceptual models treat it as a risk factor interacting with stressors and with barriers to support [5]. The model supplies masking's term in that load and one statement about where the term is largest.

Corollary 1 (Where masking's contribution to burnout is largest)**.** *Per episode, the masking load is c_M in the forced band and on the part of the region below x_u where masking pays, and* 0 *elsewhere. A person whose rooms lie in the forced band therefore accumulates masking load at the maximal rate, one unit of c_M per episode, with completion probability $e^{-\mu x_t}$, which falls to $(c_0 + c_M)/V$ at the band's upper end, beyond which the person is silent. Masking's contribution to burnout is largest exactly where masking is the only way to be heard.*

The corollary turns the note's phrase about burnout rising at the root into a location. The person for whom masking contributes most to burnout is not the person who masks by preference in rooms where unmasked speech would have served, but the person whose rooms are of the size at which unmasked speech has stopped paying and masked speech still does, which is the common size of allistic-majority company. A single further step reaches the note's spiral: when the load crosses the person's capacity to recover, burnout reduces the capacity to mask, the masked attempt's cost rises, the band narrows from below and silence arrives at a smaller room. Burnout, so reached, feeds the loop of Proposition 3.

The silence load. Masking is not the only cost the band and the region impose, and the second is the one the author's second note names: thoughts that pain the person to remain unsaid. In the model a thought s not attempted forgoes its value, and the *silence load* is $L_T^S = \sum_{t \le T} \big(V(s_t) - c_0\big) \, \mathbf{1}[s_t \in I(\lambda_t)]$, the value of what went unsaid, summed over the episodes in which it would have been said. It is zero for a thought not worth saying and largest for the thoughts that carry the situation's weight, which by Proposition 4(a) are the ones the region holds. The burnout accounts name cumulative load without adequate supports as burnout's condition [4]; the silence load is a term of that load the masking literature does not count, since nothing observable is done when it is incurred.

6 Beyond the second order: the tower, and the conflation

6.1 The tower of orders

The second-order thought was the account of why a first-order thought failed. The construction iterates. Call $s^{(1)} = s$ and let $s^{(k+1)}$ be the account of why $s^{(k)}$ was not received: the order-three thought explains why the explanation was not accepted, and so on up. Each order is an account and faces the frame, and each must carry the previous order's content together with the reason it failed, so that $\tau_{k+1} \geq \tau_k + \delta$ for some $\delta \geq 0$, the floor time a reason takes.

Proposition 6 (The tower)**.** *Under policy ρ the order-k thought is received with probability $P_k = e^{-\lambda\tau_k(1-\rho)}\,(1-\pi(1-\kappa))^{\mathbf{1}[k\geq 2]}$, and*

(a) $P_{k+1} \leq P_k$ for every k: no order is more conveyable than the one below it;

(b) if $\delta > 0$ and $\rho < 1$ then $P_k \leq P_2\, e^{-\lambda\delta(k-2)(1-\rho)}$ for $k \geq 2$, and the expected number of orders above the first that are ever received is at most $P_2/(1-e^{-\lambda\delta(1-\rho)})$, which is finite and falls as the room grows.

Proof. (a) The exponential factor is nonincreasing in τ_k and the credibility factor is at most 1 and constant from the second order. (b) $\tau_k \geq \tau_2 + (k-2)\delta$ gives the bound on P_k, and the geometric series bounds the sum. □

The tower is the Cassandra inequality run upward, and it says what explanation can and cannot do. A person who answers each failure of reception with an account of that failure climbs a tower whose steps are each less reachable than the last, and the tower has a finite reach: beyond a few orders, nothing is received at all. The person cannot explain their way out, not because explanations are poor but because each explanation is a longer turn in the same room, discounted by the same frame.

6.2 The third order: the passive example

The note records the reply that an account of the obstruction most often receives: *I have plenty of things I've never talked about with others, but you don't see it bothering me.* The reply is an event at the third order. The second-order account was heard, and its reception failed by assimilation: the listener matched it to the one model of unsaid things they possess, their own, and on that model found nothing to be bothered by. The thought that would clear the assimilation is the order-three thought, why the listener's example is not the person's case, and Proposition 6 prices it. The note calls the reply existentially cruel, and the model says in what the cruelty consists: the reply converts the person's one explanatory move into evidence for the frame. The listener has just found, in their own experience, that unsaid things do not hurt, so the person's claim that they do is read as the trait the frame already posits, and π rises. The second-order account, received this way, leaves the person worse placed than before it was made.

Why the conflation is a fallacy. The listener's inference runs from their own case to the person's: unsaid things do not bother me, so unsaid things need not bother you. The inference is valid only if the two sets of unsaid things have the same structure, and the model separates them on exactly two parameters. Write S_L for the listener's situation. The listener's turns are protected, so their conveyable region is their whole situation, $C_L = S_L$, and their unsaid things

are $U_L = \{s \in S_L : V_L(s) < c_0\}$, the thoughts not worth the saying. The person's unsaid things are $I(\lambda)$, thoughts with $V(s) > c_0$ not attempted because the room's rate makes attempting worse than silence. Both sets present as things never talked about, and they differ as follows.

(i) *Value.* The silence cost of a thought is $(V(s) - c_0)\,\mathbf{1}[s \text{ unsaid}]$, incurred at each episode in which it would have been said. On U_L it is negative or zero by construction: the listener's unsaid things are unsaid because they are not worth saying, and their silence costs nothing. On $I(\lambda)$ it is positive, and largest for the thoughts the region holds, the long ones that carry the situation. The listener's example is a case of zero silence cost offered as a model of a case of maximal silence cost.

(ii) *The option.* The listener can convert any member of U_L into a said thing by choosing to, since $C_L = S_L$; the option to speak is intact and merely unexercised. The person cannot convert any member of $I(\lambda)$, since the choice to attempt is not available at that rate: the option has been removed. The listener's example is a case of an intact option offered as a model of a removed one.

The two parameters are the note's two phrases. Things that *pain* the person to remain unsaid are (i): the silence cost is the pain, and it is paid only on thoughts worth saying. The person's *capacity to convey* under assault is (ii): the capacity is the conveyable region $C(\lambda)$, the room's rate shrinks it, and by Proposition 4(c) the shrinkage cannot be registered with the room. The listener's own region does not shrink and their example contains no capacity at all, only a choice.

Active and passive. The note's word for the difference is that the dynamic *muzzles*, and the word is exact on the model. The listener's silence is passive: it is the absence of an act, and nothing maintains it but the listener's own disinclination. The person's silence is maintained by the room, continuously: the rate λ is the sum of the room's members' interruptions, an ongoing action of others, and the silence persists exactly as long as the action does. A muzzle does not change what the animal would say; it removes the saying, and it is held on from outside. The conflation takes a silence that nothing holds in place for a silence that the room holds in place, and the fallacy is the substitution of the passive for the active. This is also why the reply, offered as reassurance, lands as an obstruction: it is spoken from inside a region in which the option is intact, to a person for whom the option is gone, by someone who cannot see the option because they have never been without it.

7 The single-root hypothesis

Hypothesis 1 (Single root)**.** Every effect classed as autistic masking, and masking's contribution to autistic burnout, is an output of the unconveyable situation of Definition 2: the first-order obstruction, the second-order obstruction, and the attribution that joins them, acting on a person who wants to be heard.

The hypothesis is the note's claim that all masking effects are outputs or shadows of a single abstraction, and the model gives the word *shadow* a sense: each named phenomenon is the one structure seen through one observable. The exponential decline of participation with company is the completion law. The double bind is the convexity. Learned silence is the threshold. Masking is the band. The experience of pressure to mask is the renewal of the band's choice at each episode. Isolation is the absorbing state. The deficit attribution is the room's update. The

Cassandra experience is the inequality. Masking's load is the band's per-episode cost, and its contribution to burnout is that cost summed. The inaccessible fraction of the situation is the fixed point's region, the untellable edge is its report-closure, the ghost is the presence quotient, the silence load is the region's forgone value, and the passive-example reply is the tower's third step. None of these needs a further cause once the structure and a person who wants to speak are given.

Three things the hypothesis does not say are stated so that it can be refuted at the right place. It does not say that masking is a choice: the band's choice is between masking and silence, and a choice between a cost and a loss is the illusion of choice the conceptual analysis of masking names [17]. It does not say that stigma is absent from the root: stigma enters as the frame π and as the premise's asymmetry, and the hypothesis locates its operative channel in conveyance. And it does not say that masking is the whole of burnout; sensory load and life stressors are contributors the hypothesis leaves where the burnout literature puts them.

What would count against it is stated in Section 9; the general form is this. Masking that persists at unchanged levels in rooms where both orders of conveyance succeed, in which turns are protected and the account of obstruction is accepted, would show a root wider than conveyance. Masking produced by stigma through channels that never touch the floor would bound the hypothesis to the channels that do. And a dissociation in which attempt rates fall with company while the room's interruption rate does not would refute the premise on which the model stands.

8 Placement

The double empathy problem. Milton's thesis is that the breakdown between autistic and non-autistic people is mutual, a disjuncture in reciprocity between two differently disposed social actors, and not a deficit on one side [18]. The present account is downstream of it and adds the asymmetry of standing. Mutual misunderstanding explains why a story told across neurotypes may not land; it does not by itself explain why one party's turns are interrupted and the other's protected, nor why one party's account of the breakdown is discounted. Definition 2 is what the double empathy problem looks like in a room where one of the two parties sets the norm of the floor.

Social motivation. The social motivation theory of autism reads reduced social engagement as reduced social interest [19]. Jaswal and Akhtar answer that the inference from appearing to being uninterested is contradicted by autistic testimony and reinterpret the behaviors it rests on [20]; the systematic review of camouflaging in pursuit of friendship finds autistic people camouflaging because they want friendship, withdrawing when the camouflage exhausts or fails while still wanting it, and concludes that the motivation theory misreads the behavior [21]. The model makes the dissociation exact. The attempt rate is set by $\lambda\tau$ against θ^*, and V, the value the person places on being heard, enters θ^* only through its logarithm and its difference with c_0: a person who wants very much to speak is silenced at a slightly larger room, and silenced all the same. Wanting is held constant while attempting falls, which is the signature the motivation theory cannot produce.

Interactional obstruction. The premise has direct support. Silver and Parsons studied how non-autistic communication partners enable or block autistic people's contributions to significant conversations and found that interruptions, unsolicited ideas and unhelpful questions functioned

as blocks, with the autistic person's communicative competence emerging relationally rather than residing in the individual [22]. Autistic adults describe group conversation as moving too fast to enter, report feeling ignored, and some withdraw into watching rather than contributing [23]; they describe themselves as a social minority who must conform to what neurotypical friends and family want and are used to, and find time with other autistic people easier [24]. Non-autistic observers form less favorable first impressions of autistic adults from brief samples, on presentation rather than content [25], which is one route by which a turn comes to lack standing before it is heard. Information passes along same-neurotype chains more effectively than along mixed ones [26], and in groups of four, rapport does not differ overall by group type [27], which bears on the symmetric prediction below.

Camouflaging and its costs. The camouflaging literature describes the forms masking takes and its costs: exhaustion, threats to identity, and poorer mental health, with the reasons autistic adults give falling into conventional and relational classes [11, 12, 14]. The model does not compete with the catalogue; it supplies the exposure at which each form is reached for and the cost each incurs per episode. Pearson and Rose argue that masking is a response to stigma rather than a strategy freely chosen [17], and the minority stress model finds everyday discrimination, internalized stigma and concealment predicting poorer mental health over general stress [28]. The band's choice between a cost and a loss is the illusion of choice stated formally, and concealment is the band's cost named from the inside.

Learned helplessness. The threshold resembles learned helplessness, in which uncontrollable outcomes produce a failure to act [29]. The resemblance is partial and the difference matters. The silence of Proposition 1(c) is a correct policy, not a failure to learn control: the person has learned the room exactly, and silence is what the room's rate makes optimal. What the person cannot do is convey that this is so.

The companion. The companion extraction develops a cost model of interaction under governing norms, the effort an interaction extracts being a baseline plus a mismatch between a person and the conventions the interaction runs on, with a within-dyad crossover designed to test it [1]. The present model is the special case in which the convention is the room's norm of the floor and the mismatch is the rate at which that norm leaves the person's turns open. The companion's Principle of Symmetry, that the designations of a reference branch and another trade places under an admissible redrawing of the scheme that produced them, predicts the mirror of 1 under autistic norms; the prediction is stated below and left to data.

9 Predictions

Each prediction names the quantity, the design and what would count against it.

P1, the floor asymmetry and the completion law. In coded recordings of mixed-neurotype group conversations, the interruption rate per minute of floor time on autistic speakers' extended turns exceeds that on non-autistic speakers' turns of the same length, and the probability that an autistic speaker completes an extended turn falls with the number of non-autistic interlocutors at fixed turn length, approximately as $e^{-n\lambda_1\tau}$, and falls faster for longer turns. Against: equal rates on turns of equal length, or completion independent of n.

P2, the Cassandra inequality. Listeners presented with a speaker's content turn and, separately, the same speaker's account of having been unable to finish it accept the account less often than the content, and the gap widens when the speaker is labeled autistic, the label raising π. A vignette design with the label manipulated between groups tests both clauses; the label's known effect on first impressions [25] supplies the manipulation check. Against: accounts accepted as often as content, or no effect of the label on the gap.

P3, wanting held constant while attempting falls. In experience sampling with separate measures of desire to contribute and of attempts made, autistic adults' desire does not vary with the size of the allistic company while their attempts fall with it, and the fall is steeper for contributions of greater length. Against: desire falling with company in step with attempts, which is the motivation theory's prediction.

P4, protecting the floor. An intervention in which one interlocutor returns the floor after each interruption raises autistic speakers' completion of extended turns, lowers state masking measured on the CAT-Q [13] adapted to the episode, and lowers anticipatory dread [23]; the effect is larger in larger rooms, since the intervention lowers λ by a fixed fraction of a larger quantity. The enabling strategies of Silver and Parsons [22] are the manipulation. Against: no effect of returning the floor on completion or on masking.

P5, absorbing silence. In longitudinal observation of a fixed room, a family or a workplace, an autistic member's silence once established persists and the room's attribution of it to the member rises, and exits occur after a change in the room's composition or after a third party supplies the situational frame, not after the member's own explanations. Against: reversals produced by the member's account alone at rates comparable to exogenous ones.

P6, the mirror. In autistic-majority rooms, non-autistic speakers show the pattern of P1 and P3 in mirror image: lower completion of extended turns than autistic speakers' turns of the same length, and attempts falling with the number of autistic interlocutors while desire does not. The same-neurotype and mixed-group designs already in use [26, 27] carry the measurement. Against: the asymmetry running the same way under both majorities, which would locate it in the autistic speaker and not in the room.

P7, the conflation. When autistic adults report obstructed conveyance to non-autistic listeners, the most frequent reply assimilates the report to the listener's own voluntary reticence, and the reply's frequency falls when the report states explicitly that the unsaid thought was one the speaker wanted to say and that the room, not the speaker, removed the option, the two parameters of Section 6. A vignette design varying the two statements tests both clauses. Against: a reply frequency unaffected by either statement, which would show the conflation not to turn on value and option.

P8, the presence quotient. Within person, the observer stance the note describes, watching the room's version of oneself in the third person, covaries with the estimated inaccessible fraction: it rises with the size of the allistic company and with the length of the thoughts the person had to convey there, and falls in rooms that protect the floor. Experience sampling with an

observer-stance item alongside the measures of P3 carries the test. Against: no within-person covariation of the stance with company or with thought length.

10 Discussion

The account relocates masking's root from the person to the room, and the relocation has a consequence for what can be done. Within the loop of Proposition 3, the person has no move: every move is a conveyance, and the state excludes conveyances. The moves are the room's. A room can protect a turn, which lowers λ; it can return the floor after an interruption, which lowers the loss from yielding; it can hold the situational frame before the person's testimony is needed, which lowers π and with it the discount on the account. Each of these is a change in the room and none is a change in the person, and P4 and P5 are the places where their effects would show.

The note's last sentence, that as an autistic person the author does not have a voice in this world, is the limit statement of the model and can be given its exact sense. A voice is a standing to be heard: a turn that is protected, an account that is credited. In a room at or beyond the threshold, the person's turns are not protected and his account of why is credited less than the turns were, so that the one thing he could say that would change the room is the thing the room is arranged not to receive. The sentence is not a report of a feeling; it is the description of a fixed point, and Section 4.5 gives the fixed point its content: a region of the person closed under the one operation that could reach it, and a presence in the room that is the complement of that region.

Three limits are stated. The case is one episode, offered as the instance that fixed the structure and not as evidence for its prevalence; the prevalence is P1's and P3's to establish. The model's quantities are not measured, and its independence assumption on interruptions and its yielding-policy simplification in Proposition 5 are conveniences a measured version would relax. And the hypothesis is scoped to masking and to masking's contribution to burnout, so that a reader who finds burnout driven in a given case by sensory load alone has found nothing against it.

A The source notes

The author wrote the note below on November 6, 2026, at 10:30 AM, within the hour of the episode it describes, and then had Claude Fable 5.1 convert it into the present paper at his direction the same day; his further notes of the same day, from which Section 4.5 and Section 6 were written, are listed after it.

> This is maybe the most concise root explanation of autistic masking that I've managed to write. (The summary is that the root itself is in the pervasive inability to convey the truth of your situation to others, which spirals into a self-reinforcing isolation—I would go so far as to argue that all autistic masking effects and their contribution to autistic burnout rising exponentially at the root are outputs or shadows of this single abstraction). I'm noticing how [redacted person visiting the house] interrupted me about six times in a span of two minutes while I was trying to explain the funny Wittgenstein rhinoceros in the room story to my dad, and then finally at the end touched me on the shoulder and literally said "I don't want to interrupt but why

don't you go help your sister download an app she's looking for". This is maybe a very good example case of why being an autistic person is a living hell: what she's effectively doing here is keeping constant pressure on me to mask, which I have to consciously resist in order to convey my thought. Being in a room full of allistic people basically scales this dynamic up by several people, that way I just give up and learn to stay quiet. Basically it's that allistic people make it artificially difficult to get even a word out of the Wittgenstein story or whatever it is, hence fueling a sense of isolation where me thinking of a funny story pathologically translates to the conclusion that I need to keep my mouth shut. Then I get criticized for not making friends like it's a problem or deficit with me in particular, which again fuels the sense of isolation and Cassandra-like inability to convey even a fragment of the real dynamic. In effect, as an autistic person, I don't have a voice in this world.

Further notes. The author's later notes, quoted as written, each with its date.

- *November 6, 2026, second note.* I would also very specifically argue that you reach a fixed point such that a major fraction of the truth of your situation becomes utterly inaccessible, effectively topologically so, to what you can convey, hence disassociation and the feeling that you're like a ghost who can only view the outside world in the third person. See what I mean? The reaction people give to this though is "I have plenty of things I've never talked about with others, but you don't see it bothering me", which is like an existentially cruel third-order obstruction because they can't see how the second order obstruction creates something more painful than their own passive example they're conflating it with! See what I mean? Like perhaps the reason the conflation is a fallacy, if I had to articulate it, is because of how this dynamic actively muzzles the autistic person, and so in the least is about things that very specifically PAIN them to remain unsaid—especially in the context of how it's their own abstract capacity to convey things itself that falls under assault by this concept. But hopefully you can push that farther based on my model than just that slight example I gave. Thanks!

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